CLIENT CONSULTANCY PROJECT | MSc MARKETING

Relaunching Ferrero Premium Ice Cream Sticks in the UK

A live client brief from Ferrero, completed as a group consultancy report and a separate individual report. MSc Marketing, University of Manchester, summer 2026.

Client	Ferrero (live brief): Premium Ice Cream Sticks, UK market
What I produced	A 3,000-word individual report, plus my sections of the group report
Evidence	Our own 129-person survey, plus Mintel, Euromonitor, Statista, YouGov, ONS, Gov.uk and company reports
Frameworks	ATR (Awareness, Trial, Repeat), SOSTAC, brand-extension fit theory, Dickson's three viability tests
Tools	R (RStudio), Python (pandas), Excel, Google Docs

MY CONTRIBUTION

My work at a glance

- **Individual report (sole author):** evaluated a proposed 500ml sharing tub and recommended a smarter alternative.
- **Group report, Chapter 4 (Recommendations):** repositioning, the "Digital Golden Passport" loyalty idea, and the awareness and distribution KPIs.
- **Group report, SOSTAC sections:** Competitor Benchmarking and Define Vision (vision statement, SMART objectives and targets).
- **Research and data:** redesigned the survey questionnaire, then cleaned and checked the data in R and reviewed the analysis against the marking criteria.

1. The challenge, in plain English

Ferrero asked a simple question: *why isn't our premium ice cream selling the way it should?* Our research found two core problems. Not enough people knew the product existed, and the people who tried it rarely bought it a second time.

38%	10.3%	53.8%	67.2%	2.76 / 5
knew the product existed (49 of 129 people)	of people who tried it bought it again	switched to a competitor (the main barrier)	expected the Ferrero Rocher praline experience	average score for value for money

Source: group primary survey, 129 respondents.

2. The group project: diagnose, then fix

As a team we used the **ATR model** (Awareness, then Trial, then Repeat) to structure the problem. Our central recommendation was to stop selling the sticks as a fancy gift ("Gifting Luxury") and sell them as an affordable everyday treat ("Everyday Premium"), the way Magnum and Häagen-Dazs already do. In other words: move the product from the "special occasion" shelf to the "treat yourself on a Tuesday" shelf.

Below are the parts of the group project that I personally owned.

2.1 Research design and data

MY CONTRIBUTION

Redesigned the survey and checked the data

- **Rebuilt the questionnaire after feedback.** I reordered it from general to specific, added a section on people's feelings about Ferrero Rocher chocolate *before* any ice cream questions, and turned vague "what if" questions into single, concrete scenarios.
- **Cut questions that would give unreliable answers,** such as asking people how much social media ads influenced them, and trimmed packaging questions to one focused question.
- **Wrote internal notes** explaining the reason behind every change, so the team could follow the logic.
- **Learned and used R to clean the data** (129 respondents, 162 columns). I spotted free-typed brand names with messy capitalisation and several brands crammed into one cell, and confirmed that blank packaging answers were by design (skip logic), not mistakes.
- **Mapped every survey question to the analysis,** found 12 question blocks that had no analysis yet, and listed missing tests (for example, linking awareness channel to purchase behaviour).
- **Analysed price-justification answers (Q46):** 46.8% said real hazelnut pieces and Ferrero chocolate would make the price feel fairer, and 42.1% said premium natural ingredients (126 of 129 answered).
- **Reviewed our analysis against the marking criteria and caught a labelling error.** One table was titled "Consumer Perceptions of Ferrero Rocher Ice Cream" but came from a question asked *before* Ferrero was introduced. I re-labelled it "General Premium Ice Cream Purchase Drivers", moved it to the category section, and rewrote it so we did not overclaim.

2.2 Strategy sections (SOSTAC)

MY CONTRIBUTION

Competitor Benchmarking

- **Built a research checklist** matching each comparison area (market share, pricing, value perception, packaging, distribution, advertising, innovation, brand awareness, HFSS regulation) to the best data source.
- **Filled a competitor snapshot table** using Euromonitor data and flagged the gaps that still needed another tool.
- **Kept the evidence clean:** the final section used external sources only, so our own survey figures were never mixed in with published market data. I also flagged that one shopper study was from 2020 to 2021.
- **The headline insight:** rivals keep refreshing with new flavours, packaging, smaller portion tubs and healthier options, while Ferrero's attention has gone to other products. Ferrero is not just behind, it is losing ground in a market where everyone else keeps moving.

MY CONTRIBUTION

Define Vision

- **Wrote the vision statement and four SMART objectives,** grounded in public sources: HFSS advertising rules (Gov.uk) and discretionary spending trends (ONS, KPMG).
- **Set realistic targets by benchmarking against similar challenger brands.** I used the actual tracked growth of Mackie's and Halo Top rather than guessing.
- **Proposed targets for the next 12 to 18 months:** awareness from 38% to about 50–55%; "favourite brand" mentions from under 1% to about 2–3%; "too expensive" complaints from 42% to about 30%.

2.3 Chapter 4: Recommendations

MY CONTRIBUTION

Owned the Recommendations chapter end to end

- **Overall direction:** a “Full Relaunch Plan” built on the ATR model, answering five business problems: perceived value, low awareness, distribution gaps, slow purchase speed, and HFSS advertising limits.
- **Repositioning** from gifting luxury to everyday personal indulgence, with sharper targeting that matched our survey findings.
- **Reworked value proposition** built around taste improvements and the Ferrero Rocher heritage, careful not to promise a flavour match we could not prove.
- **The “Digital Golden Passport”:** a loyalty mechanic designed to turn first-time buyers into repeat buyers.
- **Distribution recovery plan** to win back lost shelf presence, with KPIs for awareness and distribution so progress could be measured.
- **Used evidence from our packaging test:** purchase intent rose from 1.71 to 2.79 out of 5 after a gold-and-brown redesign.

3. My individual report: should Ferrero launch a sharing tub?

This 3,000-word report is entirely my own work. The question: **is a family-sized 500ml sharing tub a good move for Ferrero Premium Sticks?** Think of it as stress-testing one idea from the treatment plan using proper marketing science, rather than just hoping it works.

How I approached it

- **Three lenses** taken from Deng and Messinger's (2022) brand-extension fit model: does the tub fit *when and how people use* the product, does it fit the *image* of the brand, and how does *portion size* change how people feel about it?
- **Anchor and supporting theory:** Nijssen (1999) and Deng & Messinger (2022) as the backbone, supported by work such as Wakefield & Inman (2003), Ratneshwar & Shocker (1991), Dickson (1982) and Zlatevska et al. (2014).
- **A clear structure within a tight word limit:** Introduction, Literature Review, Critical Evaluation, Recommendations, Reflective Analysis and Conclusion, each with its own word budget.
- **Honest evaluation first.** I weighed the tub's genuine advantages against its weaknesses and let the evidence decide, rather than defending the idea.

MY CONTRIBUTION

My recommendation: bite-sized, mochi-style ice creams

- **The twist.** Instead of stopping at “the tub fits poorly”, I recommended small, mochi-style ice creams shaped to echo the Ferrero Rocher praline, aimed at sharing occasions.
- **Tested the market properly.** Bite-sized ice cream is an emerging category with room for differentiation: Magnum Minis (growing 8.3% faster than the category), Little Moons, Ben & Jerry's Peaces and Carte D'Or Mini Indulgence are already there. Ferrero's distinctive shape is the gap.
- **Pressure-tested it** against Dickson's (1982) three tests: is there demand, is the market big enough, and how tough is the competition?
- **Handled the cannibalisation risk.** The risk is low because the product targets sharing occasions, not gifting. I distinguished “offsetting” cannibalisation (new occasions, old ones untouched) from “destructive” cannibalisation (same occasion, lost margin).
- **Joined up the group and individual work.** I explained why the group's “Everyday Premium” repositioning and my sharing-occasion recommendation are complementary, not contradictory.

Research rigour

- **Fact-checked everything.** I verified figures against their sources before using them, for example confirming that our 38% awareness figure is exactly 49 of 129 respondents, and checking every market claim in the bite-sized section.
- **Challenged weak feedback.** When some feedback contained claims that did not hold up, I checked them against verified sources before accepting or rejecting them.
- **Chose sources carefully.** I excluded research with misconduct concerns, a paper about shrinkflation (the wrong scenario for a new launch), and a source from a weaker journal in a different market.
- **Kept theory and evidence honest:** the literature review stayed general ("could this be true for any company?"), theory always supported the recommendation, and survey data stayed separate from published data. Referencing followed Manchester Harvard style.

4. Skills this project shows

Research and analysis	Survey design, data cleaning in R, checking which statistical test fits which data, spotting what a dataset can and cannot claim
Strategy	Turning findings into a clear plan: positioning, loyalty mechanics, vision and SMART objectives, KPIs
Market and competitor insight	Benchmarking rivals using Euromonitor, Mintel, Statista, YouGov and public data; judging an emerging category
Critical thinking	Evaluating an idea honestly, then offering a better one backed by theory and evidence
Integrity and accuracy	Verifying sources, flagging dated data, refusing to overclaim
Communication	Explaining complex findings in plain English; writing to strict word limits; working across a team

5. Limitations I recognised (and what I would do next)

- **Sample skew:** our 129 respondents leaned towards 18 to 24 year olds, and some sub-groups (such as people who had tried the product) were small. A larger, more balanced sample would make the numbers firmer.
- **Missing comparison:** the survey had no Ferrero-specific version of the seven-item premium scale, so I avoided claiming a like-for-like comparison.
- **Dated sources:** some secondary data (a Häagen-Dazs shopper study) was from 2020 to 2021, so I labelled it as such.
- **Next step:** test the bite-sized concept with a short concept survey and a small in-store trial before any full launch.